

Ravi's App Teardown

A first-time user who could not answer “what is Brief?” – and the twenty-one changes he asked for, screen by screen.

Reviewer

Ravi Kumar, senior product mentor

Session

11:48 PM – 12:53 AM IST

Basis

Unprimed first use

Recorded

Wispr Flow, 8746bb3f

HIS VERDICT – READ THIS BEFORE ANYTHING BELOW

Define the primary use case and the audience segments first. Everything else on this page is cosmetic until you do.

The trap he named: if you treat the wrong thing as the core use case, incremental changes on top of it will *also* produce bad data – because the core is right for you and wrong for the user. In the beginning, don't hesitate to scrap and rebuild. Run wild experiments, not tweaks. Ship what's already designed meanwhile, and collect data.

He used the screen and still could not say what it was for. Brief and Explore read as the same product to him.

CORE

Merge Brief and Explore into one feed. Brief becomes “top headlines” inside it.

The two surfaces overlap, so neither earns its own tab. One feed, one mental model.

CORE

Kill the horizontal scroll. Go vertical, Inshorts-style.

Jacob's Law — people arrive expecting a vertical feed and spend their first seconds fighting the gesture.

CORE

Never re-serve a story the user has read. Open at story 6, not story 1.

Repetition creates fatigue, fatigue drops them to once a day, and once a day decays to zero.

HIGH

Say, on the screen, that the brief is personalised.

Nowhere does the app claim it — so the work is invisible and the value never lands.

HIGH

Make recency a weight in ranking, not a hard filter.

A hard cutoff means a user who missed two days can never resume; a weight lets them.

HIGH

Personalise the *order* of stories. Question whether to personalise the *selection* at all.

At Inc42's daily publish volume there may not be enough stories for selection-level personalisation to mean anything.

DEMOTE

Weekly recap and weekend brief must not hold homepage prominence.

Bells and whistles. They take space the core use case has not yet earned back.

Three independent sources, one finding. Ravi's “what is Brief?” matches the post-launch data (all brief loss sits at card 1, 45% advance) and the 20 Aug Brief Card UX session. This is not one person's taste.

Explore

2 changes

HIGH

Remove the auto-popping filter.

It isn't user-initiated. His first instinct was to hit X — which is the opposite of the intent.

POLISH

Changing a filter tab should reset the scroll to the top.

Today it drops you mid-list in content you never asked for.

Article view

1 change

POLISH

The progress bar should run to the end of the *article*, not the end of the *page*.

Footer, related stories and comments are counted as reading, so the bar lies about how much is left.

Companies

2 changes

Company data is the deepest earned engagement in the app — and the screen opens as if nobody arrives with a name in mind.

HIGH

Lead with search, not a discovery scroll.

People come to this tab looking for one company. Make that the first thing on the screen.

HIGH

“Recently funded” must show amount raised and valuation — not the generic card.

The numbers are the differentiator. A generic card spends the slot and says nothing DataLabs alone could say.

Streak & sign-in

1 change

HIGH

Show the 1-day streak first, then say “sign in to save it”.

Today the ask comes before any gratification — you're charging for something they haven't felt yet.

Push notifications

1 bug · iOS

Not a design note — a root cause. This is the likely explanation for “push never fired” in the post-launch data.

CAUSE

The app sends a silent / remote push, which never delivers when the app is force-killed from the switcher.

iOS will not wake a force-quit app to decide what to render, so the notification simply never appears.

FIX

Send an APS alert payload — title, body, sound — with the ID in `data`.

FCM → APNs then renders it directly instead of waking the app to check the push type.

TEST

Create an iPhone-user segment and read the delivery report.

A fresh install will not reproduce the failure, so testing on a clean device proves nothing.

Metrics he prescribed

Across the app

MEASURE

WHAT HE SAID

App opens per day per user	The single most important metric for an information app. Everything else is downstream of it.
Cohort & frequency	D0 → D1 → D2 retention chart, plus RFM segments.
Benchmark	~ 3.5 opens/day/user, or ~ 30 min/user — measured on strangers, not testers or early adopters.
The red flag	If early adopters aren't giving good numbers, it's very bad. They'll read anything.

The method he taught

For the IA rebuild

Card sorting — how to find the natural information architecture instead of arguing about it. His example: where does “diamond rings” belong on a jewellery site?

- 1 List the use cases the app actually serves.
- 2 Map each use case to an area of the app.
- 3 Have 5–10 people group them, independently.
- 4 The majority pattern is your natural IA. Build that.

“In the beginning, don't hesitate to scrap and rebuild.”

Ravi has offered to be called again as a sounding board.